Positive Publicity Case Studies: Barbie, The Super Mario Bros. Movie, and A Minecraft Movie

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Overview

My section of the project focuses on the positive side of our main question, which is how different types of social media attention connect to box office performance. While my teammates looked at negative publicity through examples like Dwayne Johnson, Chris Rock, Ezra Miller, etc. We wanted to do a comparison between negative and positive publicity from social media trends and how it affects box office revenue. For the positive publicity I chose Barbie (2023), The Super Mario Bros. Movie (2023), and A Minecraft Movie (2025). These movies were examples of positive virality and where the audience became part of the moment. People weren't just watching trailers or reading reviews. They were making memes, wearing pink outfits to the theater, screaming "chicken jockey" in their seats, and sharing those experiences online.

Each of these movies represent a slightly different version of positive virality. Barbie's hype was tied to fashion, nostalgia, and the Barbenheimer cultural moment. Super Mario drew on video game fandom and childhood memories across generations. Minecraft connected to the gaming culture and in-theater participation trends that spread on TikTok and social media. I felt like comparing all three gave a more complete picture than just looking at one movie alone.

Data Sources:

I used three data sources for this section:

• **Google Trends (9 tables):** I exported monthly search interest data and related query tables for each movie. The search interest score goes from 0 to 100, where 100 means peak interest for that movie during the time period. It is important to note that this is not actual search volume, it is a relative index, so you can compare patterns over time but not exact numbers between movies.

• **movies_clean:** This is a Kaggle dataset with 5,000 movies from 2000 to 2024. It has worldwide revenue, domestic revenue, genres, IMDb ratings, and vote counts. Barbie and Super Mario are both in this dataset. A Minecraft Movie is not, because it came out in 2025 and the dataset does not go that far yet.

• **positive_publicity_examples (hand-built table):** Because Minecraft was missing from movies_clean, I built my own small table using box office revenue figures from Box Office Mojo. This lets me compare all three movies side by side in SQL without losing Minecraft from the analysis.

Data Challenges

There were a few data issues I had to work through. The first problem was that the `Time` column in the Google Trends tables came in as a text string instead of a `DATE` type, because that is how Google Trends exports it. I used the `STR_TO_DATE()` checks on all three time series tables and confirmed there were no formatting errors, so the dates were fine to use as-is. The second issue was the `"increase percent"` column in the rising queries tables. Some rows had values like "-40%" or "300%" but others just said "Breakout." I looked this up and Breakout means the query grew by more than 5,000% and Google uses that label instead of showing an exact number because the growth is too large to compare it meaningfully. I treated Breakout as its own category and did not try to convert it into a number. The third issue was in `movies_clean`, where the `Rating` column was stored as a string like “6.997/10” instead of a decimal. I used `SUBSTRING_INDEX()` to pull out just the number before the slash whenever I needed to use rating values in a comparison.

Key Findings

I found that all three movies hit exactly 100 out of a 100 in Google Trends search interest during their release month. Barbie peaked in July 2023, Super Mario in April 2023, and Minecraft in April 2025. I didn’t expect the data to be lined up like that, what this tells me is that the hype wasn’t something that peaked early and fizzled before the movie was released. It was concentrated right at the opening, which I think is connected to why all three strong opening weekends.

The rising query data was also really interesting to look at. A Minecraft Movie and Super Mario both had 50 out of 50 of their rising queries classified as Breakout. Barbie had 43 out of 50. This tells us that almost every new search term connected to these movies was a completely new cultural conversation, not just more searches for the same things people already knew, but entirely new things people had never searched before. “Chicken jockey” is a good example, that wasn’t a term people were searching for before the Minecraft movie. It became a thing because of the movie. That kind of brand-new search behavior feels like a stronger signal of cultural impact than just seeing search volume go up.

On the box office side, all three movies performed really well. Barbie made around $1.45 billion worldwide on a $145 million budget, which is an ROI of about 899%. Super Mario made $1.36 billion on a $100 million budget, giving it the highest ROI of the three at around 1,260%. Minecraft made $960 million on a $150 million budget, an ROI of around 540%. When I compared Barbie and Mario to the average worldwide revenue for all 2023 movies in `movies_clean`, both of them ranked at the very top of their year. They were not just good, they outperformed the broader market by a lot.

One more thing I looked at was how long each movie stayed above a search interest score of 10 out of 100. Barbie and Mario each held above that level for four months. Minecraft held it for three. Barbie's longer tail makes sense to me because the conversations around that movie went beyond just the film itself. People were still talking about fashion, the cultural debate, the “Barbenheimer” moment, and what the movie meant. That kind of extended conversation kept the search interest alive in a way that the gaming movies did not quite match.

Interpretation and Limitations

Looking at everything together, I think what makes positive virality different from just any kind of online attention is that it is participatory. People were not just reacting to these movies; they were creating things around them. That is a different kind of energy than the overexposure or backlash patterns my teammates found with Dwayne Johnson. The search data supports this. Breakout queries mean new things, new conversations, new moments that would not have existed without the movie. That feels connected to why these movies performed so strongly.

That said, I want to be honest about the limitations here. Three movies is not a large enough sample to make any big statistical claims. All three also had large marketing budgets, well-known intellectual properties, and wide releases, so positive virality was definitely not the only reason they did well. The Google Trends data is also relative, not absolute, which means I cannot directly compare the exact search volumes between movies. And I cannot prove that the search interest caused the box office performance; it could just as easily go the other direction, where popular movies naturally attract more searches. What I can say is that the pattern I found in my section looks different from the patterns in my teammates' sections, and I think that difference in the type of attention is what matters most for our project's argument.